

THE WORLD'S first women

The Neolithic woman's arm bones were stronger than a modern-day rower's by up to 16%



▲ Venus of Willendorf

Plump female figurines, once linked to fertility, may represent village elders, their size conveying status. This famous example was discovered in Austria and dates back to 28,000–25,000 BCE.

PREHISTORY TO THE BRONZE AGE

Early humans were nomadic hunter-gatherers who roamed the land and survived by hunting animals and gathering other foods, such as wild plants. For decades, many anthropologists assumed that men did the hunting and toolmaking, whereas women gathered berries and took care of the children. Yet, there is no firm archaeological evidence to support this division of labor. By analyzing bones and the fractures related to hunting large game at close range, scientists have concluded that among Neanderthals—humans' closest relatives—women and children also took part in the perilous task of hunting mammoth and other big game.

The stereotype of the caveman hunter wielding his club, and the gentle wife at home with the children is, modern scholars argue, the result of 20th-century ideas of gender roles influencing the interpretation of the physical evidence. The cave paintings that began appearing in Europe about 40,000 years ago were also assumed by many later historians to be the work of men. However, a recent study of the size and structure of hands in a sample of hand stencils revealed that many of the handprints discovered in caves were actually created by women.

Venus figurines

Women were the subject of another type of prehistoric artwork—the figurine. Between 35,000–40,000 years ago, humans started to make small sculptures from bone, ivory, soft stone, or fired clay. Some sculptures represented animals, but many took the shape of voluptuous women—dubbed “Venus figurines” by archaeologists. A number of these figurines, such as those found in the early 19th century in underground burial chambers on the island of Malta, exaggerated parts of the female body associated with

